



Champion celebrated: Paris Paralympic gold medallist Navdeep Singh receives a special honour from Jayen Mehta, Managing Director, Amul, at the Sportstar Aces Awards ceremony . RITU RAJ KONWAR

Surviving on a shoestring budget marked his early days in the capital. Often, he could not afford the nutrition required to sustain an athlete's regimen. Dal and tandoori roti became his staples. Looking back, he believes that the period of struggle was instrumental in shaping his character.

"The struggle was necessary for me. It moulded me into who I am and gave me the ability to face any

challenge. During that time, I realised, '*Navdeep, tu kya hai, tu kya kar sakta hai*' (Navdeep, what are you? What can you do?). That phase was important, and I will always be grateful for it," Navdeep says.

His first breakthrough came in 2017 when he won gold at the Asian Youth Para Games in Dubai. However, life truly changed for him after his gold medal at the World Junior Para Athletics Championships

in Switzerland in 2019. He was then inducted into the Khelo India programme before securing Target Olympic Podium Scheme funding to prepare for the Tokyo Paralympics in 2021.

Being included in the country's top sports programme ensured a fixed monthly stipend and allowed him to train at the Sports Authority of India's centre in Bengaluru.

"If I compare then to now, things

